MAHARASHTRA

THE 'JIHAD' CARD

By Dhaval Kulkarni

Maharashtra may soon join the list of states with a law to curb 'love jihad'. This comes in the backdrop of a series of protests by the 'Sakal Hindu Samaj', an umbrella group of Hindu right-wing organisations, which has sought such a law. The protests have been building up since the gruesome murder of 27-year-old Shraddha Walkar in May 2022, allegedly by her live-in partner Aaftab Poonawala. Walkar hailed from Vasai near Mumbai.

State BJP legislators like Nitesh Rane, Atul Bhatkhalkar and Ram Kadam, too, have been hankering for such a law. The morchas have seen demagogues like T. Raja Singh, the suspended BJP legislator from Telangana, make hate speeches targeting the Muslim community.

The Eknath Shinde-led Maharashtra government set up a committee in December 2022 to monitor inter-faith marriages, which has already caused a furore. In the budget session, Devendra Fadnavis, the deputy CM from the BJP and who also holds the home portfolio, told the state legislative council that the government will soon decide on a legislation against 'love jihad'. Fadnavis pointed to the protests by the Sakal Hindu Samaj, saying it had attracted tens of thousands of people. "This means there is a sentiment in society about this, and the government is mindful of it," he said. Many states like Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat and Haryana already have laws that seek to punish religious conversions through force or allurement.

Fadnavis's party colleague and women and child development minister Mangal Prabhat Lodha, who set up the interfaith marriages panel, claimed in the assembly that there were over 100,000 cases of love jihad in the state. He has, however, not provided any evidence so far to establish this claim despite the clamour by the opposition.

Advocate Vikas Shinde, a member of the Pune-based group 'Right to Love' that counsels inter-faith couples and even arranges their weddings, says the love jihad law is meant to ensure religious polarisation before the local body polls slated for later this year and the Lok Sabha and assembly election later in 2024. He said instances of entrapment, if any, were too few. "If a Hindu woman loves a Muslim man, it is 'love jihad', but it is not dubbed so when a Hindu man loves a Muslim girl. Fundamentalists [across faiths] want to ensure that women have no agency," he pointed out. But then all is fair in war and politics. ■

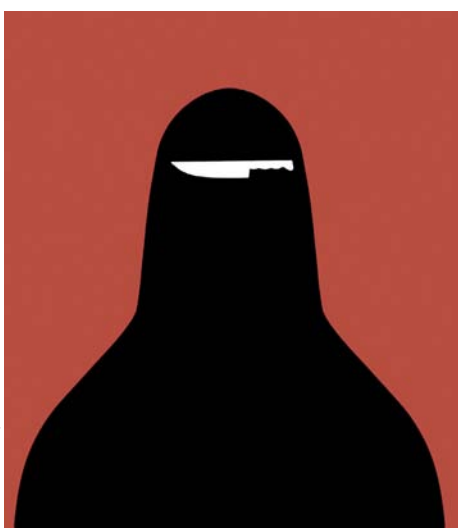


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE



J&K RECRUITMENTS

NOT QUIT

By Moazum Mohammad

Multiple developments in the past year have cast a long shadow over recruitment drives being conducted in Jammu and Kashmir. If first as many as three selection lists—of police sub-inspectors, junior engineers and finance accounts assistants—were scrapped amid allegations ranging from corruption to cheating to paper leaks, the administration courted another controversy after it hired a "tainted" external agency to conduct the examinations afresh, spurring protests by both aspirants and the Opposition in the fledgling Union Territory.

The issue surfaced last September when the recruiting agency, the J&K Service Selection Board (JKSSB), floated tenders to conduct computer-based tests to fill non-gazetted posts, including those cancelled a month prior. Starting the process afresh, the